

Eights.

A PowerPlay run rate of under eight an over since July 2024 forced the management to reshuffle at the top. Evin Lewis has been dropped, with Brandon King likely to partner Johnson Charles.

Hope has been the most prolific batter at No. 3, averaging 37, but even he could benefit from accelerating his scoring. Rovman Powell is expected to anchor the middle order, though his strike rate of 137.41 in this cycle is below his usual standards.

Shimron Hetmyer, meanwhile, has been unable to provide sustained momentum in the middle overs. While his strike rate of (176.79) remains healthy, inconsistency and limited volume (320 runs @22.85) have blunted his impact in a lineup already short on reliability.

Another concern is finding a spinner to adequately support Hosein. Gudakesh Motie and Roston Chase have been used the most, but both trail Hosein significantly, with only 15 wickets each in the same period.

The pace attack, apart from Jason Holder, remains largely inexperienced. Alzarri Joseph's absence through injury only compounds the issue.

Springing a surprise

But playing catch-up at the World Cup can be a risk-laden proposition, especially with Nepal around.

Only one run separated Nepal from South Africa in an upset win during the group stage in the last edition.

With Rohit Paudel, Dipendra Singh Airee (**pic, right**) and Sandeep Lamichhane still around, Nepal will be on the prowl against England and West Indies, hoping that a giant-killing will finally convince

world cricket of how close it is to the upper echelon.

Italy, meanwhile, will also fancy its chances of going back with a win. It defeated Scotland by 12 runs in the Europe Qualifier, and the two have been pitted together again.

Italy prepared for the World Cup

with a three-match series against Ireland and got a taste of what life without Joe Burns would look like. The former Australia batter had led the side through the Qualifier but will not feature at the World Cup due to a contractual dispute.

The 36-year-old Wayne Madsen will lead the unit in Burns' absence, in a campaign where Italy has nothing to lose and everything to gain.

(Stats as of January 22)



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Group C – T20 World Cup record

Team	Matches Played	Won	Lost	Tie	No Result	Titles won
West Indies	46	24	20	1	1	2 (2012, 2016)
England	52	28	22	–	2	2 (2010, 2022)
Scotland	22	7	13	–	2	–
Nepal	6	2	4	–	–	–
Italy	–	–	–	–	–	–